

EYEWITNESS September 17, 1862

Burnside's Bridge at Antietam

General Ambrose Burnside commanded the Ninth Corps on the Union left. He sent his troops across a narrow stone bridge over Antietam Creek, but this was overlooked by tall wooded bluffs that provided excellent cover for the Georgian sharpshooters in the Confederate line facing them. Later in the day, another crossing point was found at a nearby ford, but by then it was too late. Confederate reinforcements soon arrived and drove the Union troops back to the bridge.

“A silence fell on every one at once, for each felt that the momentous ‘now’ had come. Just as we started I saw, with a little shock, a line-officer take out his watch to note the hour, as though the affair beyond the creek were a business appointment which he was going to keep.

When we reached the brow of the hill the fringe of trees along the creek screened the fighting entirely, and we were deployed as skirmishers under their cover. We sat there two hours. All that time the rest of the corps had been moving over the stone bridge and going into position on the other side of the creek. Then we were ordered over a ford which had been found below the bridge ... One man was shot in mid stream ...

At the word a rush was made for the fences. The line was so disordered by the time the second fence was passed that we hurried forward to a shallow undulation a few feet ahead, and lay down among the furrows to re-form, doing so by crawling up into line ... A moment after, I heard a man cursing a comrade for lying on him heavily. He was cursing a dying man.

As the range grew better, the firing became more rapid, the situation desperate and exasperating to the last degree. Human nature was on the rack, and there burst forth from it the most vehement, terrible swearing I have ever heard. Certainly the joy of conflict was not ours that day ... I only remember that as we rose and started all the fire that had been held back so long was